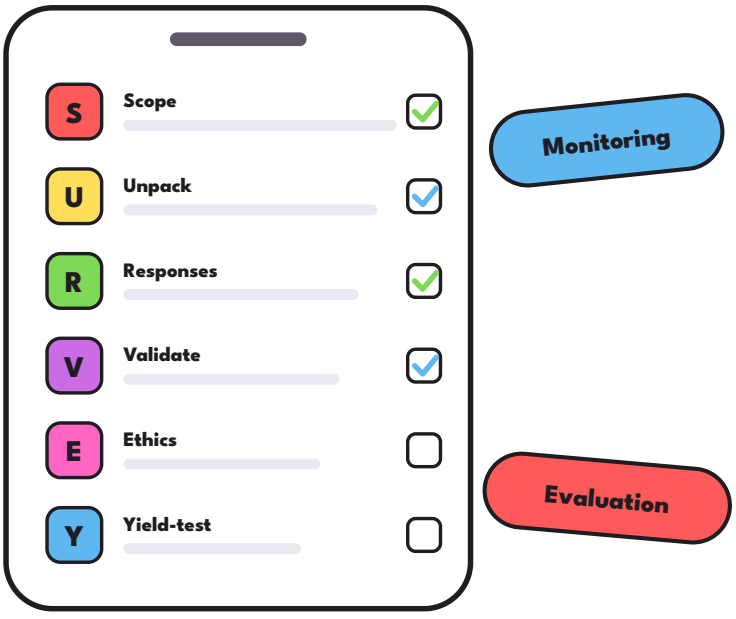
HUBFORGE.

FOR ANY FIELD · ANY TOOL

PLAYBOOK

Designing Surveys and Forms with AI

For the forms your teams fill in every week, and the surveys that show whether a programme worked. Design them well, then design them faster with AI.



HubForge Global Impact Network Foundation

www.hubforgeglobal.com · hubforgeglobal@gmail.com

How to read this FOUR WAYS IN

Start where you are.

Both kinds of instrument most programmes need: the monitoring forms teams fill every week, and the evaluation surveys that measure results. Pick the path that fits today.

Not sure what you need
Chapter 2, page 5
Monitoring form or evaluation survey?

Designing one now
Chapter 3, page 7
Six stages, both examples side by side.

Using AI to help
Chapter 7, page 21
Evidence, briefs, risks, the pact.

Running fieldwork
Chapter 11, page 30
Training, daily checks, codebook.

1 **What is wrong with these questions?** p. 3
Eight questions from eight fields. Each hides one classic flaw.

2 **Monitoring form or evaluation survey?** p. 5
One steers the work while it happens. The other judges whether it worked. Decide before you write.

3 **Six stages. One question each.** p. 7
The SURVEY method works for both kinds. Each stage asks one question of your draft.

4 **Why it works.** p. 13
Answers fail in predictable places. The method is built on decades of survey research about where.

5 **The field guide.** p. 14
The rules to keep open while you write.

6 **How you ask, and who answers.** p. 19
The same question gets different answers on a doorstep, a phone call or a screen. Design for the mode and for every respondent.

7 **Designing with AI.** p. 21
AI drafts fast and checks well. It cannot tell you what your respondents understand.

8 **The workshop.** p. 26
Four tools to use on your own draft. Each one teaches the rule behind it.

9 **From paper to phone.** p. 27
Design on paper. Pick the tool. Let AI write the XLSForm, and let the tool check it.

10 **Ready to launch?** p. 29
Ten checks for your kind of instrument. Tick them off.

11 **Fieldwork, and after.** p. 30
In a survey the interviewer is part of the instrument. After collection, the codebook and the feedback loop make the data usable and fair.

12 **The library of ideas.** p. 32
The research and practice behind every stage, a glossary of every term, and a one-page cheat sheet.

1 BEGIN WITH A TEST

What is wrong with these questions?

Eight questions from eight fields. Tick the flaw you think each one has, then turn the page.

Most data problems are designed in | The same eight flaws turn up in every sector | They are easy to miss in your own draft

1 · EDUCATION

How satisfied are you with the teachers and the school building?

- ◯ Asks two things at once
- ◯ Pushes towards an answer
- ◯ Words respondents do not use
- ◯ Options overlap or leave gaps

2 · HEALTH

Don't you agree that the new clinic hours are better?

`Yes / No`

- ◯ Vague answer options
- ◯ Pushes towards an answer
- ◯ Asks two things at once
- ◯ Sensitive, with no safeguards

3 · AGRICULTURE

How much rice did you harvest in the last five years?

- ◯ Recall that nobody can do
- ◯ Cannot be analysed at scale
- ◯ Vague answer options
- ◯ Asks two things at once

4 · FINANCE

How often do you use the app?

`Rarely / Sometimes / Often`

- ◯ Words respondents do not use
- ◯ Vague answer options
- ◯ Options overlap or leave gaps
- ◯ Pushes towards an answer

5 · WATER AND SANITATION

Is your household's WASH infrastructure functional?

`Yes / No`

- ◯ Words respondents do not use
- ◯ Asks two things at once
- ◯ Recall that nobody can do
- ◯ Sensitive, with no safeguards

6 · LIVELIHOODS

What is your household's monthly income?

`0-5,000 / 5,000-10,000 / 10,000-20,000`

- ◯ Vague answer options
- ◯ Options overlap or leave gaps
- ◯ Cannot be analysed at scale
- ◯ Pushes towards an answer

7 · GENDER AND HEALTH

Has your husband ever hit you? (asked first, at the door, with family nearby)

`Yes / No`

- ◯ Pushes towards an answer
- ◯ Words respondents do not use
- ◯ Sensitive, with no safeguards
- ◯ Recall that nobody can do

8 · YOUTH PROGRAMME

What do you think about the programme? (2,000 respondents, results needed in a week)

`Open text`

- ◯ Asks two things at once
- ◯ Cannot be analysed at scale
- ◯ Vague answer options
- ◯ Words respondents do not use

1 THE ANSWERS

The flaws, and the fixes.

Most people get five or six. The ones you missed are the flaws that slip into real forms.

1 **Asks two things at once · Education**

A parent may love the teachers and hate the building. Whatever they answer, you cannot tell which part it was about.
Better: Two questions: "How satisfied are you with your child's teachers?" and "How satisfied are you with the school building?"

2 **Pushes towards an answer · Health**

The wording tells people the answer you hope for, and many will politely give it.
Better: "Compared with the old timings, are the new clinic hours better, worse or about the same for you?"

3 **Recall that nobody can do · Agriculture**

Nobody remembers five seasons of harvests. People will guess, and the guesses will not add up.
Better: "How many kilograms of rice did you harvest in the last main season?" Ask about one season people remember.

4 **Vague answer options · Finance**

"Often" means daily to one person and monthly to another. The answers look comparable but are not.
Better: "In the last 7 days, on how many days did you use the app?" with answers 0 to 7.

5 **Words respondents do not use · Water and sanitation**

"WASH" and "infrastructure" are programme words. A respondent may not know what is being asked.
Better: "Does the hand pump nearest your home work today?"

6 **Options overlap or leave gaps · Livelihoods**

Someone earning 5,000 fits two options, and anyone above 20,000 fits none. There is also no way to decline.
Better: Up to 5,000 / 5,001 to 10,000 / 10,001 to 20,000 / More than 20,000 / Prefer not to say

7 **Sensitive, with no safeguards · Gender and health**

Asked without privacy, it puts the respondent at risk and invites silence. Sensitive questions need privacy, trained interviewers and a referral plan.
Better: Use a tested module, ask it later in the interview, only in private, with trained interviewers and a referral card ready.

8 **Cannot be analysed at scale · Youth programme**

Two thousand essays cannot be coded in a week. You will end up quoting a few and ignoring the rest.
Better: A rating, "How useful was the programme for you?", plus one short open question: "What one thing would you change?"

1

Built for collecting, not deciding

Questions go in because someone might want them. Nobody can say which decision each answer feeds, so most of it is never used.

2

Read differently by different people

Respondents, or the staff filling a form, understand a question in different ways. The numbers add up neatly and mean nothing.

3

Not built for its job

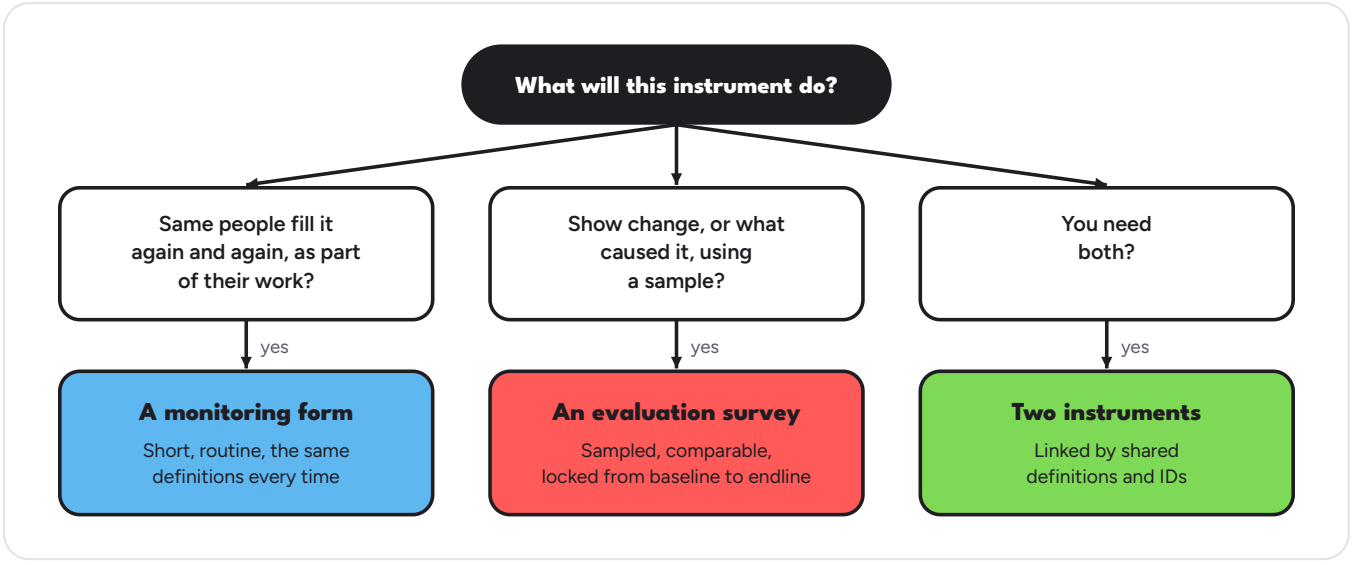
A monitoring form as long as a research survey, filled in a rush every week. Or an evaluation survey changed between baseline and endline, so change cannot be measured.

2 TWO KINDS

Monitoring form or evaluation survey?

One steers the work while it happens. The other judges whether it worked. Decide before you write.

Different jobs, people and rhythm | Monitoring: short, routine, everyone | Evaluation: sampled, comparable, locked

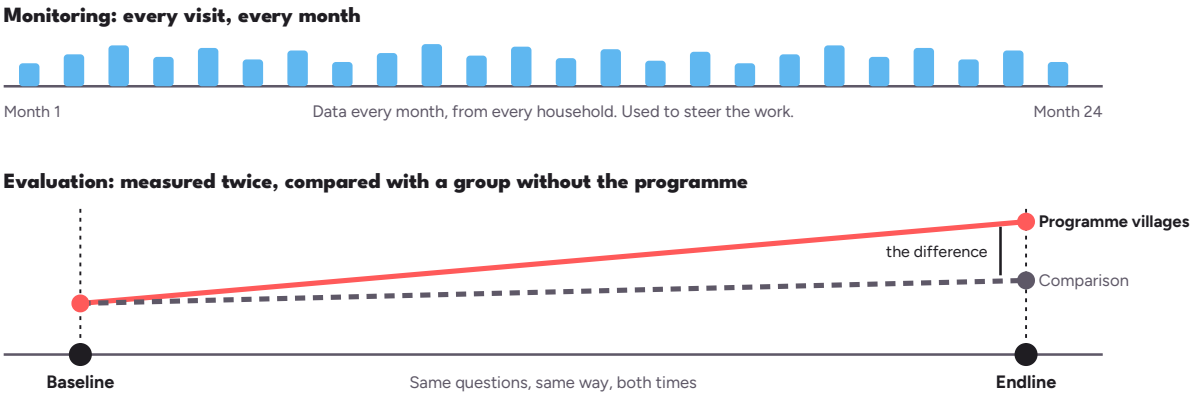


	MONITORING FORM	EVALUATION SURVEY
Its job	Track delivery and spot problems while the programme runs	Measure results and change, and what caused them
Who fills it	Programme staff, often frontline workers, as part of their work	Trained enumerators, or respondents themselves
Who it is about	Every participant, visit, session or site	A sample of people, often with a comparison group
How often	Every day, visit, week or month	Once, or at fixed points: baseline, midline, endline
How long	Minutes. It competes with the real work	Longer is acceptable, usually under 45 minutes face to face
What matters most	Speed, completeness, the same definitions every month	Validity, comparability over time, a sound sample
When you change it	Often, with a version log, as needs change	Rarely. Core questions stay identical from baseline to endline
Typical tools	Kobo, ODK, CommCare, DHIS2, Google Forms	Kobo, ODK, SurveyCTO, Survey123

2 TWO KINDS

Two rhythms, two examples.

One fictional nutrition programme, followed through the whole playbook. You need no nutrition knowledge.



MONITORING FORM

The home-visit form

A nutrition programme works in 60 villages. Forty community health workers visit pregnant women and families with young children every month. Supervisors meet every Monday and need to know three things: which households were missed, which children are not growing well, and who needs a referral.

FIRST DRAFT → AFTER THE SIX STAGES

52 → 18 fields, about 12 → 4 minutes per visit

EVALUATION SURVEY

The household survey

The same programme's funder wants to know whether young children's diets improved over two years. An evaluation team will survey 600 households in programme villages and 600 in similar villages without the programme, once at the start (baseline) and again at the end (endline).

FIRST DRAFT → AFTER THE SIX STAGES

120 → 55 questions, about 50 → 25 minutes

	Decision	Indicator	Question	Table it fills
Monitoring	Which children need a clinic referral this week?	Children whose weight fell below the expected line	Child's weight today (kg)	Children below the line, by village and worker
Evaluation	Did the programme improve children's diets?	Share of children 6 to 23 months with minimum dietary diversity	Food groups the child ate yesterday (standard module)	Share meeting the indicator, programme vs comparison, baseline vs endline

3 · The SURVEY method. The SURVEY method works for both kinds. Each stage asks one question of your draft.

S

THE SURVEY METHOD · STAGE 1 OF 6

Scope

Which decisions will this data change?

Start from decisions, not questions.

Start from decisions, not questions. For each decision, name who makes it and when, the indicator that informs it, and the empty table you will fill. A question that feeds no table is cut, however interesting it is.

THE HOME-VISIT FORM

Three Monday decisions became three indicators. 34 of the 52 fields fed none of them, so they went.

HOME-VISIT FORM — S

52 fields became 18

Met the family?	Visits done
Child's weight today	Growth
~~Roof material~~	~~no decision~~
~~Distance to market~~	~~no decision~~

THE HOUSEHOLD SURVEY

The evaluation question fixed one main indicator, the sample, and a baseline that cannot change. 65 questions fed nothing.

HOUSEHOLD SURVEY — S

120 questions became 55

Food groups eaten yesterday	Diet indicator
Child's date of birth	Age 6 to 23 m
~~Programme knowledge quiz~~	~~no eval question~~
~~Favourite recipes~~	~~no eval question~~

AI can help: Map each draft question to an indicator, and list those that map to nothing.

The ideas behind this: Data analysis plan and dummy tables · Utilization-focused evaluation · Logframes and results frameworks · Respondent burden

Your turn

for your own form or survey

- [ ] Name each decision, who makes it and when
- [ ] One indicator per decision
- [ ] Draw the empty table each one fills
- [ ] Cut every question that fills nothing

THE SURVEY METHOD · STAGE 2 OF 6

U Unpack into questions

Will everyone understand it the same way?

Write it the way the person answering would say it.

Answering takes four steps: understanding, remembering, judging and answering. Write one idea per question, in the words of whoever answers, with a clear time period. Reuse tested questions wherever they exist.

THE HOME-VISIT FORM

"Nutritional status" became "Child's weight today (kg)". A worker can answer it in seconds.

HOME-VISIT FORM U

Words the worker uses

~~Nutritional status of the child~~

Child's weight today (kg)

~~Counselling provided?~~

Did you discuss feeding with the mother today?

THE HOUSEHOLD SURVEY

Home-made feeding questions gave way to the standard WHO and UNICEF module, so results compare with national data.

HOUSEHOLD SURVEY U

A standard module

~~Do you give your child a balanced diet?~~

Yesterday, during the day or night, did the child eat any of these foods?

Grains · Pulses · Dairy · Eggs · ...

AI can help: Check each question against BRUSO and suggest plain rewrites for the person who answers.

The ideas behind this: The four steps of answering · BRUSO · Use tested questions first · Infant and young child feeding indicators

Your turn

for your own form or survey

- [ ] One idea per question
- [ ] A clear time period
- [ ] The words of whoever answers
- [ ] Tested questions where they exist

THE SURVEY METHOD · STAGE 3 OF 6

R Responses

Can everyone find exactly one answer that fits?

Everyone finds exactly one answer that fits.

Answer options must be exhaustive and must not overlap. Use counts instead of vague words, label every scale point, and give honest exits: "don't know", "prefer not to say", "not applicable".

THE HOME-VISIT FORM

Weight must be 1 to 30 kg. "Child not present" is an option, so a missing weight is never a zero.

HOME-VISIT FORM R

Every answer has a home

Child's weight today (kg)

`constraint` between 1 and 30

Is the child present now?

Yes | No

THE HOUSEHOLD SURVEY

Overlapping income ranges were fixed. "Rarely, sometimes, often" became a count over the last 7 days.

HOUSEHOLD SURVEY R

Every answer has a home

In the last 7 days, on how many days did you buy fruit?

~~Rarely / Sometimes / Often~~

0 | 1 to 2 | 3 to 4 | 5 to 7 | Don't know

AI can help: Find overlaps, gaps and vague frequency words in the options, and show every boundary value.

The ideas behind this: Exhaustive, non-overlapping options · Labelled response scales · Recall periods and telescoping · Don't know and prefer not to say

Your turn

for your own form or survey

- [ ] Exhaustive options, no overlaps
- [ ] Every scale point labelled
- [ ] Counts instead of vague words
- [ ] Honest exits: don't know, not applicable

THE SURVEY METHOD · STAGE 4 OF 6

V Validate the flow

Does each person see only what applies, in a sensible order?

Each person sees only what applies, in a sensible order.

Order shapes answers: consent first, easy questions early, sensitive ones later. Skip logic hides what does not apply; constraints stop impossible answers at entry; calculations save people doing sums in their heads.

THE HOME-VISIT FORM

Child questions appear only if there is a child. A low weight brings up the referral question on its own.

HOME-VISIT FORM V

Only what applies

- **No child under two** · child questions hidden
- **Weight below the line** · referral question appears

`calculation` age in months

THE HOUSEHOLD SURVEY

A roster repeats for each member. Feeding questions appear only for children aged 6 to 23 months.

HOUSEHOLD SURVEY V

Modules and a roster

- **Roster** · repeats for each member
- **Child 6 to 23 months** · feeding module appears

`begin_repeat` one block per member

AI can help: Draft skip logic and constraints as a table, then walk the form as three different respondents.

The ideas behind this: Question order and context effects · XLSForm · Satisficing · Unique IDs and longitudinal data

Your turn

for your own form or survey

- [ ] Consent first, sensitive later
- [ ] Constraints on every number and date
- [ ] Skip logic for follow-ups
- [ ] Walk it as three different people

E

THE SURVEY METHOD · STAGE 5 OF 6

Ethics and every language

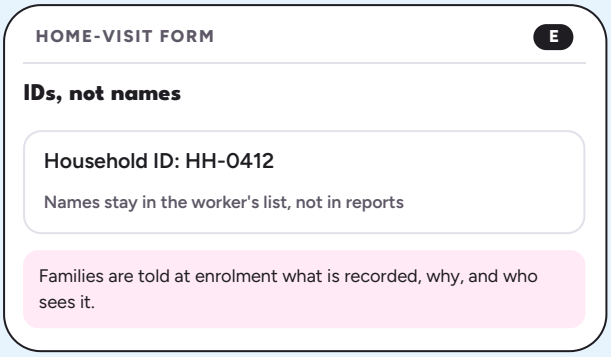
Is it safe to answer, and does it mean the same in every language?

Safe to answer, and the same meaning in every language.

People give their time and information. Ask for consent in plain words, collect only the personal data a decision needs, and keep identities apart from answers. Translate as a team: two translations, a review, a decision, a pretest.

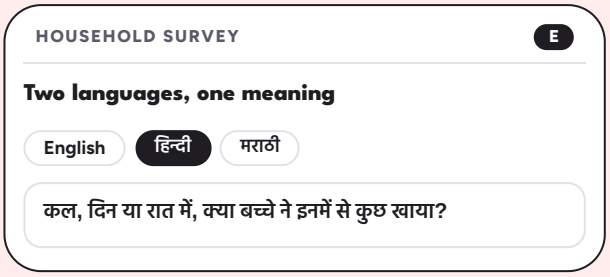
THE HOME-VISIT FORM

Families are told what is recorded and why. Reports use household IDs, never names.



THE HOUSEHOLD SURVEY

Consent comes first. Two translators, one reviewer, and food names checked with people in the villages.



AI can help: Draft a plain consent script and a first translation, listing words with no direct equivalent.

The ideas behind this: Informed consent · Data minimisation · TRAPD team translation · Why back-translation is not enough

Your turn

for your own form or survey

- ☐ Only the personal data you need
- ☐ Two translations, reviewed together
- ☐ IDs instead of names in reports
- ☐ A plain consent script

THE SURVEY METHOD · STAGE 6 OF 6

Y Yield-test

Have real people used it before everyone does?

Real people use it before everyone does.

Test before launch, and keep checking after. Watch real people use the instrument, fix what confuses them, and set up checks so problems show up in days, not months.

THE HOME-VISIT FORM

Five workers, one week of real visits. Two fields moved. A weekly completeness check after rollout.

HOME-VISIT FORM Y

Tested on real visits

Workers	Per visit
5	4 min

"I weigh the child before I talk to the mother." Two fields moved.

THE HOUSEHOLD SURVEY

Eight cognitive interviews, a 30-household pilot, then daily checks and one in ten households revisited.

HOUSEHOLD SURVEY Y

Tested, then locked

Cognitive interviews	Pilot households
8	30

"Yesterday he was sick." A check question was added for unusual days.

AI can help: Draft a test plan, then flag odd patterns in pilot data, with no names or numbers in it.

The ideas behind this: Cognitive interviewing · Pilot testing · High-frequency checks and back-checks · Routine data quality assessment

Your turn

for your own form or survey

- [ ] Watch real people use it
- [ ] Checks that run every day or week
- [ ] Fix, then test the fixes
- [ ] A version number for every change

4 WHY IT WORKS

Why it works.

Answers fail in predictable places. The method is built on decades of survey research about where.

Every answer passes through four mental steps

Error comes from who answers and what answers mean

People answer well when it feels worth it

Every answer takes four steps Tourangeau, Rips and Rasinski, 2000

1

Understand

What is being asked?

Fails with: Jargon, two ideas in one, vague words

~~"Is the WASH infrastructure functional?"~~

Protected by U

2

Remember

What do I know about it?

Fails with: Recall that is too long, no time period

~~"How much rice did you harvest in the last five years?"~~

Protected by U R

3

Judge

What is my answer?

Fails with: Leading words, unlabelled scales, wanting to look good

~~"Don't you agree the new clinic hours are better?"~~

Protected by R E

4

Respond

Which option is mine?

Fails with: Overlapping or missing options, no honest exit

~~"5,000 to 10,000 / 10,000 to 20,000"~~

Protected by R V

Error comes from two sides Total survey error, Groves and Lyberg, 2010

Measurement: Does the answer mean what we think?

Validity. The question does not measure the concept the decision needs. S U

Measurement error. People misread, misremember, or answer to please. U R V

Processing error. Typos, impossible values, wrong codes after collection. V Y

Representation: Are the right people answering?

Coverage. Some people are missing from the list you start from. S

Sampling. Chance differences between your sample and everyone. Agree the size with a statistician. S

Nonresponse. People refuse, drop out or skip, and they differ from those who answer. E Y

What research says about people and forms

Answering is an exchange

People take part when trust and benefit outweigh the cost. Say why, say how long, keep your promises.

Dillman, Smyth and Christian, 2014

A form is a conversation

Ask in the order a polite person would: who you are and why, easy questions first, sensitive ones later.

Jarrett and Gaffney, 2008

Tired people take shortcuts

When effort runs out, people agree, pick the first option, or say "don't know". Short and relevant beats long and complete.

Krosnick, 1991

One thing per screen

On a phone, one question per screen is easier to read, answer and correct. Group questions only after testing.

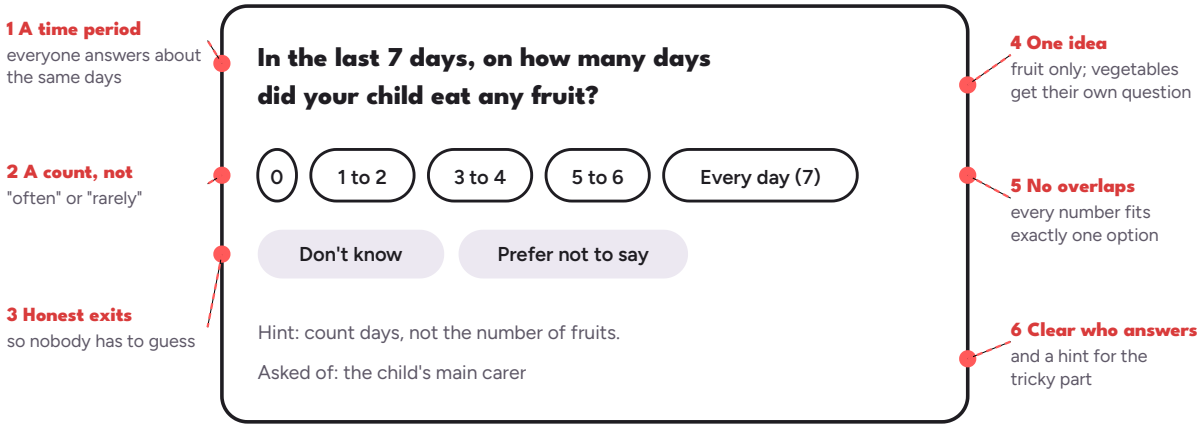
Tim Paul, GOV.UK, 2015

5 FIELD GUIDE

The field guide.

The rules to keep open while you write.

Six parts of a good question | Ten wording rules, each with a fix | A bank of tested questions to borrow



Ten wording rules

1 One idea per question

~~Were the staff polite and quick?~~

Were the staff polite? / Were the staff quick?

2 Use the respondent's words

~~Was your grievance redressed?~~

Has the problem you called about been solved?

3 Give a time period

~~Do you visit the clinic?~~

In the last 3 months, how many times did you visit the clinic?

4 Stay neutral

~~How much did you enjoy the training?~~

How useful or not useful was the training for your work?

5 THE FIELD GUIDE

More wording rules.

Each rule with a question that breaks it and one that keeps it.

5 **Ask about the person, not everyone**

~~Do people in your village use the toilet?~~

Does anyone in your household use the toilet at home?

6 **Avoid negatives**

~~Do you not disagree that fees should not rise?~~

Should school fees go up, stay the same or go down?

7 **Ask what people can know**

~~How much did the government spend on your road?~~

Has the road to your village been repaired in the last year?

8 **Avoid absolutes**

~~Do you always wash hands before eating?~~

Yesterday, before eating, did you wash your hands?

9 **Keep it short**

~~Thinking about the various services that may or may not have been offered to you over the period of the programme, which...~~

Which of these services did you receive?

10 **Prefer tested questions**

~~Writing your own disability questions~~

Use the Washington Group Short Set

Answer options

Counts beat vague words

"Rarely, sometimes, often" means different things to different people. Ask for a number of days, times or people in a set period.

Exhaustive and exclusive

Every respondent finds exactly one option. Check each boundary (5,000 or 5,001?) and add "other, please say" when you cannot list everything.

Label every scale point

Five labelled points are easier to answer and to compare than a 1 to 10 line with labels only at the ends.

Item-specific over agree-disagree

"How easy or difficult was it to reach us?" works better than "It was easy to reach us: agree or disagree", which invites yes-saying.

Plan for not knowing

Offer "don't know" and "prefer not to say" where they are honest answers, and code them separately, not as zero.

Forced choice over check-all

"Did you receive X? Yes or no" for each item gets more complete answers than one long tick-all-that-apply list.

Fit recall to memory

Big, rare events can be recalled over a year. Small, frequent ones need a short period: yesterday, the last 7 days.

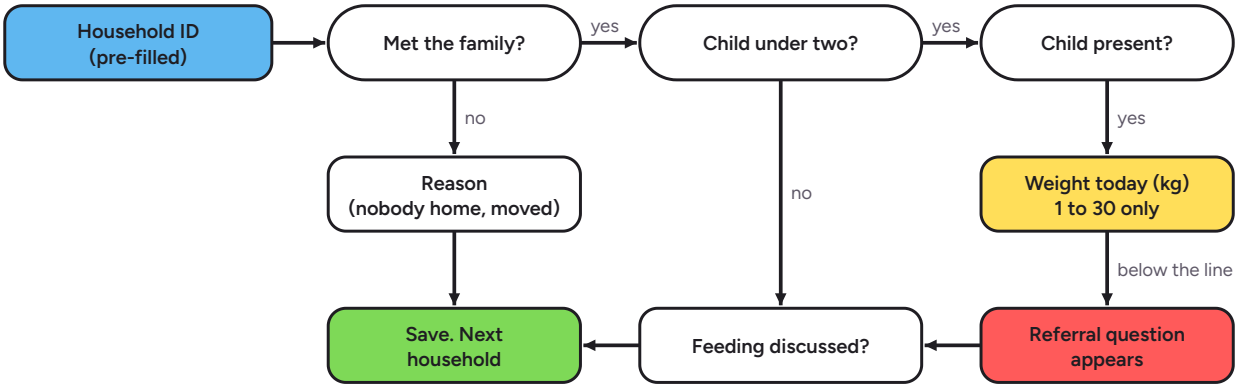
Keep open questions few

One or two short open questions add the "why". More than that, and nobody will code them.

5 THE FIELD GUIDE

Flow and logic.

Logic decides who sees what. In a monitoring form it does much of the work.



A NATURAL ORDER FOR A SURVEY

1. Introduce, then ask for consent
2. Screen: is this the right person?
3. Easy, factual questions to build trust
4. The core topic, in a natural order
5. Sensitive questions, with privacy
6. Background details last
7. Thank them, and say what happens next

LOGIC PATTERNS, IN XLSFORM

Show only if
Ask a follow-up only when it applies.

```
relevant ${solved} = 'no'
```

Allowed range
Stop impossible answers at entry.

```
constraint . ⩾ 1 and . ⩽ 30
```

Must answer
Make key questions required; leave sensitive ones optional.

```
required yes
```

Depends on a choice
Filter one list by an earlier answer, such as villages by district.

```
choice_filter district = ${district}
```

Calculate
Work out a value, such as total household members.

```
calculation ${adults} + ${children}
```

Selected in a multi-choice
Follow up on one option of a tick-all question.

```
relevant selected(${services}, 'counselling')
```

Repeat for each
Ask the same block for every child or every plot.

```
begin_repeat repeat_count: ${children}
```

5 THE FIELD GUIDE

Consent and privacy.

Evaluation respondents consent before an interview. Monitoring data is personal too.

EVERY CONSENT SCRIPT SAYS

1. Who you are and who is asking
2. Why, and how answers will be used
3. How long it takes
4. That taking part is voluntary, and they can stop or skip at any time
5. How answers are kept private, and who sees them
6. Who to contact with questions or complaints
7. A clear yes before the first question

COLLECT LESS, PROTECT MORE

- **Need it?** If no decision uses a personal detail, do not collect it.
- **IDs, not names.** Keep the list linking IDs to people separate and locked.
- **Hide small groups.** Never report a group so small someone could be recognised.
- **Plan for distress.** For sensitive topics, train interviewers and carry referral details.
- **Know your law.** Data protection rules, such as GDPR or India's DPDP Act, cover monitoring data too. Evaluations may also need ethics review.

THE HOUSEHOLD SURVEY'S CONSENT SCRIPT

E

"Hello, my name is ____, and I work for an independent team studying how families in this area feed young children. I would like to ask you some questions about your household and your youngest child. It takes about 25 minutes. Your answers are confidential: your name will not be written with them, and nobody in the village will see them. You can skip any question or stop at any time, and saying no will not affect any services you receive. May I begin?"

5 THE FIELD GUIDE

A bank of tested questions.

Before you write a question, look for one that has been tested. Copy it from the source document, adapt only what you must, and note the change.

HEALTH

DHS Program model questionnaires

Child health, maternal care, family planning

dhsprogram.com/Methodology/Survey-Types/DHS-Questionnaires.cfm

HEALTH

UNICEF MICS questionnaires

Child wellbeing, education, water, protection

mics.unicef.org/tools

NUTRITION

WHO and UNICEF IYCF indicators, 2021

Infant and young child feeding, dietary diversity

www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240018389

FOOD SECURITY

FAO Food Insecurity Experience Scale

Experience of food insecurity, eight questions

www.fao.org/measuring-hunger/access-to-food/applying-the-fies/en

FOOD SECURITY

WFP Food Consumption Score

Household food consumption

resources.vam.wfp.org/

POVERTY

World Bank LSMS questionnaires

Consumption, income, assets, agriculture

www.worldbank.org/en/programs/lsms

POVERTY

Poverty Probability Index (Innovations for Poverty Action)

Likelihood of living below a poverty line, about ten questions

www.povertyindex.org/

DISABILITY

Washington Group Short Set

Difficulty in six functional domains

www.washingtongroup-disability.com/

WATER AND SANITATION

WHO and UNICEF JMP core questions

Drinking water, sanitation, hygiene service levels

washdata.org/

EDUCATION

ASER, EGRA and EGMA, and the MICS Foundational Learning module

Foundational reading and maths

asercentre.org/

EARLY CHILDHOOD

UNICEF ECDI2030

Development of children aged 2 to 5

data.unicef.org/resources/early-childhood-development-index-2030-ecdi2030/

GENDER

IFPRI WEAI

Women's empowerment in agriculture

weai.ifpri.info/

FINANCE

World Bank Global Findex questionnaire

Accounts, savings, borrowing, digital payments

www.worldbank.org/en/publication/globalfindex

WORK

ILO labour force survey model questionnaires

Employment, hours, earnings

ilostat.ilo.org/

ANY TOPIC

World Bank and IHSN microdata libraries

Thousands of past questionnaires, searchable

microdata.worldbank.org/

6 MODES AND PEOPLE

How you ask, and who answers.

The same question gets different answers on a doorstep, a phone call or a screen. Design for the mode and for every respondent.

Each mode has its own rules | Design for low literacy and disability | Protect people on sensitive topics

Mode	Length	Best for	Watch for	Design rules
Face to face	Up to about 45 minutes	Long or complex surveys, rosters, measurements, low-literacy respondents, places with weak phone coverage. *Show card: In the last 7 days, on how many days did your child eat fruit? Point to the number.*	Interviewer effects: who asks shapes what people say Others in the room change answers on sensitive topics Costly travel, so fewer households and fewer revisits	Use show cards for long lists and scales Ask for privacy before sensitive modules Record GPS and start and end time automatically
Phone call	Under about 20 minutes	Quick follow-ups, panels you have already met in person, monitoring calls to workers or clients. *In the last 7 days, on how many days did your child eat fruit? You can say a number from zero to seven.*	People without phones, or sharing one, are missed Nobody can see a show card, so long lists get lost Others may overhear the respondent	Read no more than four or five options No grids; turn them into separate short questions Plan five to eight call attempts at different times
Online, self-completed	About 10 to 12 minutes	Staff, partners, teachers, students, or any connected group that reads comfortably. *In the last 7 days, on how many days did your child eat fruit? [0] [1] [2] … [7]*	Only reaches people who are online and confident reading No one to explain a confusing question Speeding and straight-lining through grids	One question per screen on phones Label every scale point; avoid long grids Show progress, and say how long it takes
SMS	About 5 to 10 short questions	Very short pulse checks with people who already know you, such as programme participants. *Days your child ate fruit in last 7 days? Reply 0 to 7.*	About 160 characters per message Literacy and language limits Who actually holds the phone	One idea per message, answered with a single number Send a thank-you and a way to stop Never ask for names or sensitive details
Voice (IVR)	About 5 minutes	Short checks with people who cannot read, in their own language. *Did your child eat any fruit yesterday? Press 1 for yes. Press 2 for no.*	Hang-ups after the first minute Keypad answers must be very simple Recordings must be clear and in local speech	Two or three options per question, pressed as 1, 2, 3 Repeat the options once Record in the local dialect, tested with real listeners
Paper	As short as possible	Places with no devices, or as a backup. Many monitoring systems still start on paper registers. *Q12. Days child ate fruit, last 7 days: [_] (0 to 7)*	No automatic skips or checks, so more errors Delay and errors when data is typed in later Lost or damaged forms	Print skip instructions next to the answers ("If No, go to Q8") Boxes for each digit of numbers and IDs Enter data twice, or check a sample against the paper

Mixing modes, such as phone for some and face to face for others, can change answers even when the words are the same. Keep wording identical across modes where you can, record the mode for every interview, and compare answers by mode before pooling. *(de Leeuw, 2005)*

6 MODES AND PEOPLE

Design for the people least likely to be heard.

Low literacy, sensitive topics, disability, and choosing who answers.

Low literacy

- **Read every question aloud.** Even on self-completed forms, offer an audio option or an interviewer.
- **Show cards with pictures.** Pictures of food groups, coins or a ladder help people choose without reading.
- **Use local units.** Bags, tins and handfuls, not kilograms, with conversions done later.
- **Practise once.** A warm-up question shows how the scale or card works before the real ones.

Sensitive topics

- **Make it private.** Interview alone, or hand over the device so people can enter answers themselves.
- **Ask later, and gently.** Build trust first. Say why you ask, and that skipping is fine.
- **Normalise the answer.** "Many families find it hard to…" makes an honest answer easier than a bare yes or no.
- **Ask indirectly.** List experiments count how many items apply, so no one reveals which.
- **Plan for distress.** Train interviewers to stop, comfort and refer. Carry referral details.

Disability and access

- **Identify, then include.** The Washington Group questions show who has difficulty seeing, hearing, walking, remembering, self-care or communicating.
- **Adapt the mode.** Large text, screen-reader friendly web forms, audio, or more time.
- **Careful with proxies.** Ask the person first. If someone answers for them, record that it was a proxy.

Who answers

- **Name the right person.** The mother for child feeding, the farmer for the plot, not whoever opens the door.
- **Avoid needless proxies.** People report less accurately on others' lives than on their own.
- **Match where norms require.** Women interviewing women can change what is said about health or household decisions.

The ideas behind this: Asking sensitive questions · List experiments · Show cards and pictures · Washington Group Short Set · Mixing modes · Phone survey practice

7 WITH AI

Designing with AI.

AI drafts fast and checks well. It cannot tell you what your respondents understand.

Brief it like a colleague | Know its six typical mistakes | Keep the six promises

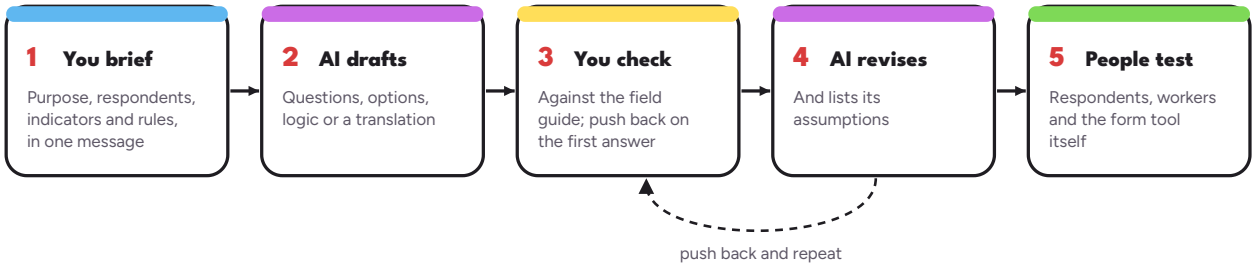
75% A 2026 test planted known flaws in 20 survey questions. With a guided prompt, a language model caught about three in four, cheaply and in under an hour. It also found different problems from expert reviewers. **Use AI to screen a draft early. Then still test with real people.** *(Sturgis, Roberts and Robinson, 2026)*

AI is good at

- Drafting first versions of questions and options
- Spotting double questions, jargon and overlaps
- Turning a questionnaire into an XLSForm
- Suggesting skip logic and constraints
- A first translation, with hard words listed
- Pointing you to standard question sets
- Checking pilot data for odd patterns

AI is not good at

- Knowing what your respondents actually understand
- Judging whether a question is culturally appropriate
- Guaranteeing the form works without testing it
- Knowing which decisions really matter to your programme
- Replacing fluent human translators and reviewers
- Quoting them exactly; it often paraphrases or invents them
- Seeing your data safely, unless your organisation approved it



Six things in every brief

1 Who answers, and their language and schooling	2 Monitoring form or evaluation survey, and how it is collected	3 The decisions and indicators the data serves
4 Your draft, or the topics to cover	5 The rules: one idea per question, labelled options, honest exits	6 What you want back, and in what format

7 WITH AI

Two real sessions, and six mistakes.

One session turns a paper register into a monitoring form. The other uses AI to find a standard module, not to write one.

BUILDING THE HOME-VISIT FORM

YOU
Here is our paper home-visit register (52 fields) and the three decisions supervisors make each Monday. Turn it into a phone form for health workers. Keep only fields that feed those decisions, pre-fill the household ID, and add constraints for every number. Give me an XLSForm survey and choices sheet.

AI, A TYPICAL REPLY
I kept 18 fields. Weight has a constraint of 1 to 30 kg; visit date cannot be after today. I added a calculated field for months of age and a referral question that appears when weight is below the expected line. Assumption: the household ID comes from a list loaded into the form.

YOU
Show me which of the 34 removed fields a supervisor might still miss, and why each is safe to drop.

FINDING A STANDARD MODULE

YOU
We are evaluating whether young children's diets improved. Our respondents are mothers and carers with primary schooling, interviewed face to face in Hindi. Which standard, tested question set measures dietary diversity for children 6 to 23 months? Do not write the questions; tell me the source.

AI, A TYPICAL REPLY
The WHO and UNICEF infant and young child feeding indicators, updated in 2021, include minimum dietary diversity: at least five of eight food groups eaten yesterday. Use the questionnaire module from the official guidance document, and check whether a national survey has already translated it.

YOU
Good. Now list what could make "yesterday" hard to answer for some mothers, and how to handle it.

1

Invented "standard" questions

AI paraphrases a well-known module or makes one up that sounds official.

Check: Copy standard questions from the source document, never from the AI's answer.

2

Plausible but wrong logic

Skip rules that look right but leave someone at a dead end.

Check: Walk the form on a phone as three different respondents.

3

Overlapping options

Ranges like 1 to 3 and 3 to 7, written confidently.

Check: Check every boundary value yourself.

4

Translation drift

Fluent translations that shift the meaning, or use formal words nobody says.

Check: Two translators and a fluent reviewer decide.

5

Synthetic respondents

AI "pretends to be" a respondent and finds no problems.

Check: Use AI respondents only for typos and broken logic; pretest with people.

6

Personal data leaks

Pasting real answers, names or phone numbers into a tool.

Check: Use made-up or fully de-identified data unless the tool is approved.

7 WITH AI

The AI pact.

Eight jobs AI does well, what you keep in each, and six promises that hold whatever the tool.

1
Scoping partner
Maps each question to a decision and an indicator.
You keep: deciding what matters

2
Plain-language editor
Flags jargon, double questions and leading words.
You keep: final wording

3
Option checker
Finds overlaps, gaps and vague frequency words.
You keep: checking every boundary

4
Logic writer
Drafts skip logic, constraints and the XLSForm.
You keep: testing it on a phone

5
First translator
Produces one draft and lists hard words.
You keep: review by fluent people

6
Source finder
Points to standard modules and where to get them.
You keep: copying from the real source

7
Test-plan writer
Drafts interview guides and pilot checks.
You keep: doing the interviews

8
Data checker
Flags odd patterns in pilot and field data.
You keep: deciding what is an error

The one it can't play: the person on the other end of the question.

Six promises to keep

1 **Every question earns its place**
Each one feeds a decision and a planned table.

2 **No respondent data goes in**
No names, phone numbers or raw answers in an AI tool unless your organisation approved it.

3 **Standard questions come from the source**
Copied from the official document, never from AI memory.

4 **Translations are reviewed**
Fluent reviewers decide, and every choice is noted.

5 **Logic is tested on a device**
By people walking every path before launch.

6 **AI help is disclosed**
The methods note says what AI drafted and who checked it.

7 WITH AI

Conversation starters.

Three openings for each stage. Replace the highlighted words, then push back on the first answer.

S Scope

Map to decisions

Here are our decisions: `[decisions]`. For each question in this draft, name the indicator it serves and mark the ones that serve none: `[draft]`.

Then push back: "Which three questions would you cut first, and what would we lose?"

Draft dummy tables

For each indicator `[indicators]`, draft the empty table we will fill, with rows, columns and breakdowns.

Then push back: "Which table would no decision-maker look at?"

Find the source

Which standard, tested question sets exist for `[topic]`, such as from DHS, MICS, LSMS or the Washington Group? Give the source documents, not the questions.

Then push back: "Where would these standard questions not fit our respondents?"

U Unpack

BRUSO review

Review each question against BRUSO: brief, relevant, unambiguous, specific, objective. Our respondents are `[respondents]`. Flag problems and suggest rewrites: `[questions]`.

Then push back: "Which rewrite would a person with primary schooling misunderstand?"

Paper to phone

Here is our paper register: `[paste]`. Rewrite each field as a question a `[worker]` can answer in seconds during a visit.

Then push back: "Which fields would they fill from memory after the visit, and how do we prevent that?"

Four steps

For each question, say where the person answering could struggle: understanding, remembering, judging or answering.

Then push back: "Which question asks people to remember too much?"

R Responses

Fix the options

Make these answer options exhaustive and non-overlapping, and add "don't know", "prefer not to say" or "not applicable" where honest: `[questions and options]`.

Then push back: "Show me every boundary value and which option it falls into."

Counts, not vague words

Turn every vague frequency word in these questions into a count over a set period: `[questions]`.

Then push back: "Is that recall period realistic for this behaviour?"

Ranges for numbers

Suggest realistic minimum and maximum values for each number in this form, for `[population]`: `[questions]`.

Then push back: "Which limits could block a real but unusual answer?"

V Validate

Write the logic

Write skip logic and constraints for this questionnaire as a table: question, show only if, allowed answers: `[questionnaire]`.

Then push back: "Which respondent would reach a dead end?"

Write the XLSForm

Turn this questionnaire into XLSForm survey, choices and settings sheets, with snake_case names and relevant expressions using ${name}: `[questionnaire]`.

Then push back: "List every list_name and check each select question uses one that exists."

Walk it through

Walk through this form as three respondents: `[profiles]`. List every question each one sees.

Then push back: "Which question would feel odd or intrusive to one of them?"

E Ethics and language

First translation

Translate this questionnaire into `[language]` for `[respondents]`. List words with no direct equivalent and give two options.

Then push back: "Which choices change the meaning, not just the wording?"

Consent script

Draft a short, plain consent script covering who we are, purpose, time, voluntary participation, privacy and contacts, for a `[mode]` survey.

Then push back: "What would a nervous respondent still be unsure about?"

Privacy scan

Review this form for personal data we do not need, and answers that could identify someone in a small group.

Then push back: "What could we collect less of and still answer every decision?"

Y Yield-test

Cognitive interview guide

Write a cognitive interview guide for these questions: a think-aloud prompt and two probes each: `[questions]`.

Then push back: "Which probe might lead the respondent?"

Field test for a form

Draft a one-week field test of this monitoring form with `[number]` workers: what to observe, and what would make us change a field.

Then push back: "What would workers never tell a supervisor about the form?"

Pilot data check

In this pilot data, with no names or numbers, flag high "don't know" rates, identical answers across a grid and very short interviews: `[summary]`.

Then push back: "Which flags are real problems and which are expected?"

8 WORKSHOP, ON PAPER

The question doctor.

Run each draft question past these twelve checks, then ask your AI for two rewrites of anything that fails. The web version checks questions as you type.

- [ ] **Two ideas in one?**
  Contains "and" or "or"? Split it.
- [ ] **Vague frequency**
  "Often", "regularly", "recently". Ask for a count.
- [ ] **Long recall**
  Five years, "ever". Shorten it.
- [ ] **Double negatives**
  Two "nots". Rewrite positively.
- [ ] **Hypothetical**
  "Would you". Ask what they did instead.
- [ ] **Overlapping options**
  A boundary value fits two options.
- [ ] **Leading wording**
  "Don't you agree", "how much did you enjoy". Offer both sides.
- [ ] **No time period**
  Behaviour without "in the last 7 days" or similar.
- [ ] **Absolute words**
  "Always", "never". Ask about one occasion.
- [ ] **Programme words**
  Jargon or acronyms respondents do not say.
- [ ] **Too long**
  Over 20 words, especially read aloud.
- [ ] **No way out**
  No "don't know", "not applicable" or "other".

How long will it take?

QUESTION TYPE	SECONDS EACH
Yes/no and choose-one	12
Choose-any	20
Number or date	15
Item in a rating grid	8
Open question	45

Add up the seconds, then adjust. **Monitoring form**: × 0.9, with a limit of about **5 minutes** per use. **Survey**: add 90 seconds for the introduction, then × 1.6 face to face, × 1.5 by phone, × 0.75 online. Tiredness starts to hurt quality above roughly **45 minutes** face to face and **12** by phone or online.

The home-visit form went from about 12 minutes to 4. The household survey from about 50 to 25.

9 BUILD IT

From paper to phone.

Design on paper. Pick the tool. Let AI write the XLSForm, and let the tool check it.

A few questions pick the tool | Two ready XLSForms to download | The converter is your spell-checker

Will people work without internet?
Kobo, ODK, SurveyCTO, CommCare, Survey123

Do you visit the same people again and again?
CommCare, or ODK Entities; for national health systems, DHIS2

Is it short and online only?
Google Forms or Microsoft Forms

Is the data sensitive?
Tools with encryption: SurveyCTO, ODK, Kobo

Do you need maps?
Survey123, or any tool with a GPS question

Tool	How you build	Offline	Languages	Cost	Best for
KoboToolbox	XLSForm or a drag-and-drop builder	Yes, on Android and in the browser	Strong; many languages in one form	Free plan with usage limits; paid plans	Humanitarian and development surveys
ODK	XLSForm	Yes, ODK Collect on Android	Strong	Open source; host it yourself or pay for hosting	Teams wanting full control of data
SurveyCTO	XLSForm, online builder	Yes	Strong	Paid	Large studies, encryption, field monitoring
CommCare	Visual app builder	Yes	Strong	Free tier; paid plans	Following the same people over time
DHIS2	Web forms and Android app	Yes	Good	Open source; often run by health ministries	Routine health monitoring at scale
ArcGIS Survey123	XLSForm or web designer	Yes	Good	Needs an ArcGIS licence	Location-heavy data and maps
Google Forms	Web editor; branching by section	Limited; best with a connection	One language per form	Free	Quick online surveys of connected respondents
Microsoft Forms	Web editor; branching	Limited	Multilingual forms	With Microsoft 365	Organisations already on Microsoft 365

Plans, prices and limits change; check each tool's current pages before you choose.

1
Finish the questionnaire
Wording, options, logic and translations agreed in a document first.

2
Ask for three sheets
Survey, choices and settings, with snake_case names and ${name} in every rule.

3
Upload and read the errors
Kobo and ODK reject broken forms with a message. Paste it back to the AI and fix.

4
Test on a phone
Walk through as three different respondents. Check every skip and every range.

9 BUILD IT

An XLSForm on one page.

XLSForm is a spreadsheet that describes a whole form. This is the home-visit form, checked with ODK Validate. Both example forms can be downloaded from the web version.

survey

type	name	label	required	relevant	constraint
select_one hh	hh_id	Household ID	yes		
date	visit_date	Date of visit	yes		. ⩽ today()
select_one met	met	Did you meet the family today?	yes		
select_one yn	child_u2	Is there a child under two in the household?	yes	${met} = 'yes'	
date	child_dob	Child's date of birth	yes	${child_u2} = 'yes'	. ⩽ today()
calculate	age_months			${child_u2} = 'yes'	
select_one yn	present	Is the child present now?	yes	${child_u2} = 'yes'	
decimal	weight	Child's weight today (kg)	yes	${present} = 'yes'	. ⩾ 1 and . ⩽ 30
select_one refer	refer	Weight is low for age. Did you refer the child to the clinic?	yes	${present} = 'yes' and ${weight} < 7	
select_one yn	feeding	Did you discuss feeding with the mother today?	yes	${met} = 'yes'	
note	done	Visit saved. Thank you.			

choices

list_name	name	label
hh	hh_0412	HH-0412
hh	hh_0413	HH-0413
hh	hh_0418	HH-0418
met	yes	Yes
met	nobody	No, nobody home
met	moved	No, moved away
yn	yes	Yes
yn	no	No
refer	yes	Yes
refer	refused	No, family refused
refer	other	No, other reason

MONITORING FORM

home_visit_xlsform.xlsx

- Pre-filled household list
- Date and weight constraints
- Age in months, calculated
- Referral question when weight is low

EVALUATION SURVEY

household_survey_xlsform.xlsx

- Consent gate before any question
- Household roster as a repeat group
- Feeding module for children 6 to 23 months
- Food groups counted; diversity flag calculated

10 READY?

Ready to launch?

Ten checks for each kind of instrument. Print this page and tick off the column for yours.

Separate lists for each kind | Most failures are caught here | Print it for the team

MONITORING FORM

Before rollout

- [ ] Every field feeds a decision someone makes
- [ ] Definitions match the programme's indicator guide
- [ ] Takes minutes, not a quarter of the visit
- [ ] IDs pre-filled; no names in reports
- [ ] Constraints on every number and date
- [ ] Skip logic tested on workers' own phones, offline
- [ ] Tested on real visits by a few workers
- [ ] Version number and change log in place
- [ ] Weekly completeness and quality check set up
- [ ] Supervisors know what they will see, and when

Score: ____ / 10

EVALUATION SURVEY

Before fieldwork

- [ ] Every question maps to an evaluation question
- [ ] Standard modules used, copied from the source
- [ ] Sample size and comparison group agreed
- [ ] Core questions locked for baseline and endline
- [ ] Options exhaustive, with honest exits
- [ ] Translations reviewed by fluent people
- [ ] Consent script approved, and ethics review where needed
- [ ] Cognitive interviews and a pilot done
- [ ] Enumerators trained on every question
- [ ] Daily checks and back-checks planned

Score: ____ / 10

11 FIELDWORK AND AFTER

Fieldwork, and after.

In a survey the interviewer is part of the instrument. After collection, the codebook and the feedback loop make the data usable and fair.

Train interviewers question by question | Check data every day, not at the end | Give results back to the people who answered

THE INTERVIEWER MANUAL

For every question, the interviewer manual says:

1. Why it is asked
2. Definitions, such as who counts as a household member
3. Allowed probes and clarifications
4. What to do with unusual answers

EXAMPLE, FOR ONE QUESTION

"How many people usually live and eat in this household?"

WHY	Sets the roster and every per-person figure.
DEFINITION	Slept here most nights in the last 3 months and shares meals. Include babies; exclude guests.
PROBE	"Anyone working away who usually lives here?"
IF UNSURE	Note it, and ask your supervisor the same day.

Training: four steps before the field

1 Classroom
Question by question, with the manual. Everyone reads every question aloud.

2 Role play
Pairs practise the full interview, including refusals and hard cases.

3 Field practice
Real interviews outside the sample, checked the same day.

4 Test and select
A short test and observed interview before anyone is hired for fieldwork.

During fieldwork: check every day, by interviewer

1 Daily checks
Duration, missing and "don't know" rates, outliers and skips, by interviewer.

2 Back-checks
Revisit or call about one in ten households and repeat key questions.

3 Accompaniment
Supervisors sit in on some interviews every week.

4 Paradata
Timestamps and time per question flag interviews that were rushed or invented.

MONITORING FORMS For monitoring forms, the people filling them are staff. Give a short orientation, a one-page job aid, and send them a summary of their own data every month so they see it used.

11 FIELDWORK AND AFTER

Seven habits after collection.

They make the data usable by anyone, and fair to the people who gave it.

1 Codebook
For every variable: name, label, type, codes, missing codes, and who was asked. Write it as you build the form; XLSForm is half of it already.

2 Missing codes
Keep "don't know", "refused" and "not asked" apart, for example -98, -99 and a blank from skip logic. Never store them as zero.

3 "Other, please specify"
Read the answers early. Recode common ones into new options, and add them to the form for the next round.

4 Versions
Every change gets a version number and a line in a change log, and each record stores the version it was collected with.

5 Cleaning log
Record every correction, why it was made, and who made it. Keep the raw data untouched.

6 Close the loop
Tell respondents, workers and communities what you found and what will change. It is respectful, and it raises response next time.

7 Keep, then delete
Decide how long you keep personal data, who can see it, and when it is deleted.

A first codebook, from the household survey

Variable	Label	Type	Codes	Missing	Asked of
hh_size	People who usually live and eat here	integer	1 to 30	-98 don't know	All who consent
m_age	Age in completed years	integer	0 to 110	-98, -99	Each member
foods	Food groups eaten yesterday	select_multiple	grains … none	not asked: blank	Child 6 to 23 months
mdd	Minimum dietary diversity	calculated	1 = 5 or more groups	blank if not asked	Child 6 to 23 months
fruit_days	Days fruit bought, last 7	select_one	d0, d12, d34, d57	dk	All who consent

The ideas behind this: Interviewer effects · Interviewer training · High-frequency checks and back-checks · Paradata · Codebooks and data documentation · Missing codes · Closing the feedback loop

12 GO DEEPER

The library of ideas.

53 concepts, research findings and practices this playbook stands on, each with something to do on Monday.

The four steps of answering
How people answer · Roger Tourangeau, Lance Rips and Kenneth Rasinski, 2000
Every answer goes through understanding, remembering, judging and responding.
On Monday: For each tricky question, ask which of the four steps a respondent might trip on.

Satisficing
How people answer · Jon Krosnick, 1991
Tired or bored respondents give answers that are good enough, not accurate.
On Monday: Shorten the survey and put the most important questions early.

Social desirability
How people answer · Survey methodology research
People give the answer that sounds good, not always the true one.
On Monday: Ask sensitive behaviour about a specific recent time, without judgement in the wording.

Acquiescence and agree-disagree scales
How people answer · Willem Saris and colleagues, 2010
Many people say "agree" whatever the statement.
On Monday: Rewrite agree-disagree items as direct questions with labelled answers.

Order of answer options
How people answer · Jon Krosnick and Duane Alwin, 1987
Options read first or last get chosen more often.
On Monday: Keep lists short, and randomise order where it has no natural sequence.

Social exchange and tailored design
How people answer · Don Dillman, Jolene Smyth and Leah Melani Christian, 2014
People respond when trust and benefit outweigh the cost of answering.
On Monday: Read your introduction aloud. Does it say why, how long, and what happens to the answers?

Asking sensitive questions
How people answer · Roger Tourangeau and Ting Yan, 2007
People under-report what looks bad and over-report what looks good.
On Monday: Move sensitive questions to self-completion or a private moment, and normalise honest answers in the wording.

List experiments
How people answer · Graeme Blair and Kosuke Imai, 2012
People say how many items apply, not which ones.
On Monday: Use for one or two very sensitive questions, with a statistician; it needs a larger sample.

BRUSO
Wording · Robert Peterson, 2000
Brief, relevant, unambiguous, specific, objective.
On Monday: Run every draft question through the five letters before piloting.

Double-barrelled questions
Wording · Survey methodology research
A question that asks two things gets one answer you cannot interpret.
On Monday: Split any question that contains two ideas.

Leading and loaded questions
Wording · Survey methodology research
Wording that hints at the right answer.
On Monday: Offer both sides in the question: "better, worse or about the same".

Use tested questions first
Wording · DHS, MICS, LSMS and similar survey programmes
Many topics already have questions tested across countries.
On Monday: Search the standard questionnaires before writing your own.

Washington Group Short Set
Wording · Washington Group on Disability Statistics
Six tested questions on difficulty with everyday activities.
On Monday: Use it instead of asking "do you have a disability?"

Infant and young child feeding indicators
Wording · WHO and UNICEF, updated 2021
Standard indicators and questions on how young children are fed.
On Monday: Use the official module and its exact wording when you measure child diets.

Exhaustive, non-overlapping options
Answer options · Survey methodology research
Every respondent should find exactly one answer.
On Monday: Check every boundary value against the options.

Labelled response scales
Answer options · Jon Krosnick and Stanley Presser, 2010
Fully labelled scales of five or seven points work well.
On Monday: Label every point in words, not only the ends.

Forced choice over check-all-that-apply
Answer options · Jolene Smyth and colleagues, 2006
Asking yes or no for each item gets more complete answers.
On Monday: For important lists, ask yes or no for each item.

Recall periods and telescoping
Answer options · John Neter and Joseph Waksberg, 1964
People pull events into the recall period that happened before it.
On Monday: Match the recall period to how memorable the event is.

Don't know and prefer not to say
Answer options · Survey methodology research
Honest non-answers need a place.
On Monday: Code them separately and never as zero.

Show cards and pictures
Answer options · Common survey practice
A printed card lets people see the options instead of remembering them.
On Monday: Make a show card for any question with more than four options asked face to face.

Data analysis plan and dummy tables
Planning · Common evaluation practice
Plan the tables before writing the questions.
On Monday: Draw the empty tables for each indicator first.

Utilization-focused evaluation
Planning · Michael Quinn Patton, first edition 1978
Design for the intended use by intended users.
On Monday: Name the decision-makers and decisions before writing a question.

Respondent burden
Planning · Survey methodology research
Every minute you ask for has a cost.
On Monday: Estimate interview time and cut until it fits.

Monitoring and evaluation
Planning · Common practice in programme management
Monitoring tracks delivery as it happens; evaluation judges results and causes.
On Monday: Decide which one each instrument serves before writing any question.

Logframes and results frameworks
Planning · Development programme practice
A table linking activities, outputs, outcomes and their indicators.
On Monday: Start every form from the indicator list, not a blank page.

Sampling and sample size
Planning · Survey statistics
How many, and which, people to ask.
On Monday: Agree the sample with a statistician before finalising the survey length.

Baseline, endline and comparison groups
Planning · Evaluation practice
Measuring change needs the same question asked the same way, twice.
On Monday: Lock core questions after baseline; change only what you must, and note it.

Total survey error
Planning · Robert Groves and Lars Lyberg, 2010
Every survey number carries error from two sides: who answered, and what the answers mean.
On Monday: Name the one error source most likely to hurt your main indicator, and design against it first.

Question order and context effects
Flow · Howard Schuman and Stanley Presser, 1981
Earlier questions change how later ones are answered.
On Monday: Ask general questions before specific ones on the same topic.

XLSForm
Flow · XLSForm community standard
A spreadsheet format that describes a whole form.
On Monday: Keep your questionnaire in XLSForm so it moves between tools.

Unique IDs and longitudinal data
Flow · Monitoring practice; tools such as CommCare and ODK Entities
One ID per person or household links every visit.
On Monday: Decide the ID system before building the first form.

Forms as a conversation
Flow · Caroline Jarrett and Gerry Gaffney, 2008
A form is a conversation between an organisation and a person.
On Monday: Check your order against how a polite person would ask in real life.

One thing per page
Flow · Tim Paul, GOV.UK Design Notes, 2015
Start with one question per screen; merge only when testing shows it helps.
On Monday: On phones, keep one question per screen unless the questions are a tight group, such as a date.

Mixing modes
Flow · Edith de Leeuw, 2005
Different modes can produce different answers to the same question.
On Monday: Record the mode for every interview, keep wording the same across modes, and compare by mode before you pool.

Phone survey practice
Flow · Innovations for Poverty Action, Knowledge Hub
Keep phone surveys short, and plan many call attempts.
On Monday: Cut your phone survey to the questions that serve a decision, and plan call times when people are free.

TRAPD team translation
Languages and ethics · Janet Harkness; Cross-Cultural Survey Guidelines
Translate, review, adjudicate, pretest, document.
On Monday: Plan for two translators and a reviewer, even on a small survey.

Why back-translation is not enough
Languages and ethics · Cross-Cultural Survey Guidelines
Translating back to the original can hide problems.
On Monday: Ask a fluent reviewer to judge the translated questions themselves.

Informed consent
Languages and ethics · Research ethics practice
People agree knowing what they agree to.
On Monday: Read the consent script aloud in the pilot and see if people can repeat it back.

Data minimisation
Languages and ethics · Data protection laws, such as GDPR and India's DPDP Act 2023
Collect only the personal data you need.
On Monday: For every personal detail, ask whether a decision needs it.

Closing the feedback loop
Languages and ethics · Feedback Labs and others
Tell people what you heard and what you will do.
On Monday: Plan how results go back to respondents, workers and communities before you collect.

Cognitive interviewing
Testing and quality · Gordon Willis, 2005
Ask a few people to think aloud as they answer.
On Monday: Interview five to ten people from the target group before any pilot.

Pilot testing
Testing and quality · Survey practice
A small run in real conditions.
On Monday: Pilot with twenty or thirty respondents, then fix and pilot the fixes.

High-frequency checks and back-checks
Testing and quality · Practice from research groups such as IPA and J-PAL
Check data every day, and re-ask a sample.
On Monday: Set daily checks before fieldwork starts.

Paradata
Testing and quality · Mick Couper, 1998
Data about how the data was collected.
On Monday: Turn on audit or timing features in your form tool.

Routine data quality assessment
Testing and quality · Practice from programmes such as MEASURE Evaluation
Regular checks that routine data is complete, timely and accurate.
On Monday: Schedule a small data quality check every quarter.

Interviewer effects
Testing and quality · Brady West and Annelies Blom, 2017
Answers vary by who asks, not only by who answers.
On Monday: Train question by question, check data by interviewer every day, and spread each interviewer across areas.

Codebooks and data documentation
Testing and quality · Common practice; standards such as DDI
A codebook explains every variable so anyone can use the data correctly.
On Monday: Export your XLSForm sheets and add a column for missing codes; that is a first codebook.

Missing codes
Testing and quality · Common survey practice
"Don't know", "refused" and "not asked" are different and must stay different.
On Monday: Agree missing codes before collection and write them into the codebook.

Interviewer training
Testing and quality · Common field practice
Training is where wording becomes the same question for every respondent.
On Monday: Budget several days of training for a new survey, including at least one day in the field.

Limits of synthetic respondents
AI · Lisa Argyle and colleagues, 2023
AI can imitate survey answers for some groups, but not reliably.
On Monday: Use AI respondents only to find typos and broken logic.

AI in survey translation
AI · Research on generative AI in TRAPD, 2024
AI can draft translations; people still review.
On Monday: Let AI produce one of the two drafts, then review as usual.

Automation bias
AI · Raja Parasuraman and Victor Riley, 1997
People trust automated suggestions too readily.
On Monday: Check every AI-written skip rule on a device.

AI for question pretesting
AI · Patrick Sturgis, Caroline Roberts and Thomas Robinson, 2026
A well-prompted model found about three in four known flaws in a test set.
On Monday: Screen your draft with AI early, then still run cognitive interviews with real people.

12 GO DEEPER

Glossary.

40 terms used in this playbook, in plain words.

back-check: Revisiting some respondents to repeat key questions and confirm the data.

baseline: The first measurement, before or at the start of a programme.

calculation: A value the form works out itself, such as age in months from a date of birth.

CAPI: Computer-assisted personal interviewing: face to face with a tablet or phone.

CATI: Computer-assisted telephone interviewing.

change log: A record of every change to a form, with its version number and date.

choice list: The set of answer options for a select question, kept in the choices sheet.

codebook: A document listing every variable, its label, codes and missing codes.

cognitive interview: A test where people think aloud as they answer, to show how they understand each question.

comparison group: People similar to participants who did not get the programme, showing what would have happened anyway.

constraint: A rule that rejects impossible answers, such as a weight over 30 kg for a toddler.

de-identified: Data with names and other identifiers removed or replaced by codes.

double-barrelled: A question that asks about two things at once.

dummy table: An empty table, drawn before collection, showing how each indicator will be reported.

endline: The final measurement, at the end of a programme, compared with the baseline.

enumerator: A trained interviewer who asks the questions and records answers.

evaluation survey: A survey of a sample, often at baseline and endline, to judge whether a programme worked.

high-frequency check: Automatic daily checks on incoming data, by interviewer.

indicator: A measure that tells you about progress or results, such as the share of children with a healthy weight.

informed consent: A person's free agreement to take part, after hearing what it involves.

instrument: The questionnaire or form itself.

logframe: A table linking activities, outputs, outcomes and their indicators.

mode: How a survey is delivered: face to face, phone, online, SMS, voice or paper.

monitoring form: A short form filled again and again, usually by staff as part of their work, to steer a programme.

paradata: Data about the interview itself, such as timestamps, duration and edits.

PII: Personally identifiable information, such as names, phone numbers or exact locations.

pilot: A small trial run of the whole survey or form before the real one.

proxy: Someone answering on behalf of another person.

recall period: The stretch of time a question asks about, such as the last 7 days.

relevant: The XLSForm column that holds skip logic: when a question is shown.

repeat group: A block of questions asked once for each person, plot or visit.

respondent: The person who answers the questions.

roster: A list of household members, with a few questions about each, usually built as a repeat group.

sample: The people chosen to answer, standing in for a larger population.

satisficing: Giving an answer that is good enough rather than accurate, usually because of tiredness.

show card: A printed card listing options or pictures, shown to the respondent during an interview.

skip logic: Rules that show or hide a question depending on earlier answers.

social desirability: Answering in the way that looks good rather than what is true.

TRAPD: A team approach to translation: translate, review, adjudicate, pretest, document.

XLSForm: A spreadsheet format for building digital forms, read by Kobo, ODK, SurveyCTO and Survey123.

Designing Surveys and Forms with AI

First, decide

Monitoring form	Same people, as part of their work, again and again. Minutes, not a quarter of the visit.
Evaluation survey	A sample, often with a comparison group, at baseline and endline. Core questions locked.

The SURVEY method

S **Scope: Start from decisions, not questions.**
Name each decision, who makes it and when · One indicator per decision · Draw the empty table each one fills

U **Unpack into questions: Write it the way the person answering would say it.**
One idea per question · The words of whoever answers · A clear time period

R **Responses: Everyone finds exactly one answer that fits.**
Exhaustive options, no overlaps · Counts instead of vague words · Every scale point labelled

V **Validate the flow: Each person sees only what applies, in a sensible order.**
Consent first, sensitive later · Skip logic for follow-ups · Constraints on every number and date

E **Ethics and every language: Safe to answer, and the same meaning in every language.**
Only the personal data you need · IDs instead of names in reports · Two translations, reviewed together

Y **Yield-test: Real people use it before everyone does.**
Watch real people use it · Fix, then test the fixes · Checks that run every day or week

Every answer takes four steps

Understand → Remember → Judge → Respond. Find the step a question trips on, and fix that.

Ten wording rules

1. **One idea per question.** Were the staff polite? / Were the staff quick?
2. **Use the respondent's words.** Has the problem you called about been solved?
3. **Give a time period.** In the last 3 months, how many times did you visit the clinic?
4. **Stay neutral.** How useful or not useful was the training for your work?
5. **Ask about the person, not everyone.** Does anyone in your household use the toilet at home?
6. **Avoid negatives.** Should school fees go up, stay the same or go down?
7. **Ask what people can know.** Has the road to your village been repaired in the last year?
8. **Avoid absolutes.** Yesterday, before eating, did you wash your hands?
9. **Keep it short.** Which of these services did you receive?
10. **Prefer tested questions.** Use the Washington Group Short Set

Answer options

- Counts beat vague words
- Label every scale point
- Plan for not knowing
- Fit recall to memory
- Exhaustive and exclusive
- Item-specific over agree-disagree
- Forced choice over check-all
- Keep open questions few

Order: consent, screen, easy facts, core topic, sensitive with privacy, background, thanks.

Modes, rules of thumb

Face to face	Up to about 45 minutes; use show cards for long lists and scales
Phone call	Under about 20 minutes; read no more than four or five options
Online, self-completed	About 10 to 12 minutes; one question per screen on phones
SMS	About 5 to 10 short questions; one idea per message, answered with a single number
Voice (IVR)	About 5 minutes; two or three options per question, pressed as 1, 2, 3
Paper	As short as possible; print skip instructions next to the answers ("if no, go to q8")

With AI: six promises

1. **Every question earns its place.** Each one feeds a decision and a planned table.
2. **No respondent data goes in.** No names, phone numbers or raw answers in an AI tool unless your organisation approved it.
3. **Standard questions come from the source.** Copied from the official document, never from AI memory.
4. **Translations are reviewed.** Fluent reviewers decide, and every choice is noted.
5. **Logic is tested on a device.** By people walking every path before launch.
6. **AI help is disclosed.** The methods note says what AI drafted and who checked it.

Before launch

- Every question feeds a decision or an evaluation question
- Standard modules copied from the source
- Options exhaustive, with honest exits
- Logic tested on a phone by three people
- Consent script and privacy plan agreed
- Pilot done; timings known
- Version number and change log in place

In the field: daily checks by interviewer; back-check one in ten; separate codes for don't know, refused and not asked; share results back.

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Designing Dashboards with AI Playbook and **Workbook**: the DESIGN loop for any dashboard tool.

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